



PRIME VIDEO

HUNTING MISSY'S KILLER

AN INVESTIGATIVE JOURNALIST HAS
MADE IT HER MISSION TO CATCH THE
MAN WHO ABDUCTED AND MURDERED
A 19 YEAR OLD IN ARKANSAS BACK IN 1994



Melissa was taken
from a bowling alley



Missy Witt was loved. Her mother Mary Ann cherished her, and she was a popular student at Westark Community College in Fort Smith, Arkansas. She worked part-time as a dental assistant and planned on becoming a dental hygienist, where her sunny, outgoing nature would have been invaluable. But Missy, as she was affectionately known, never got to live those dreams, because on 1 December 1994, she was abducted and murdered. Her killer has not been caught, but along with detectives who have worked the case for decades, a woman who never even met Missy – victim advocate and investigative journalist LaDonna Humphrey – has made it her mission to bring him to justice. Her journey is followed in Prime Video's *Uneven Ground: The Melissa Witt Story*.

ABDUCTED

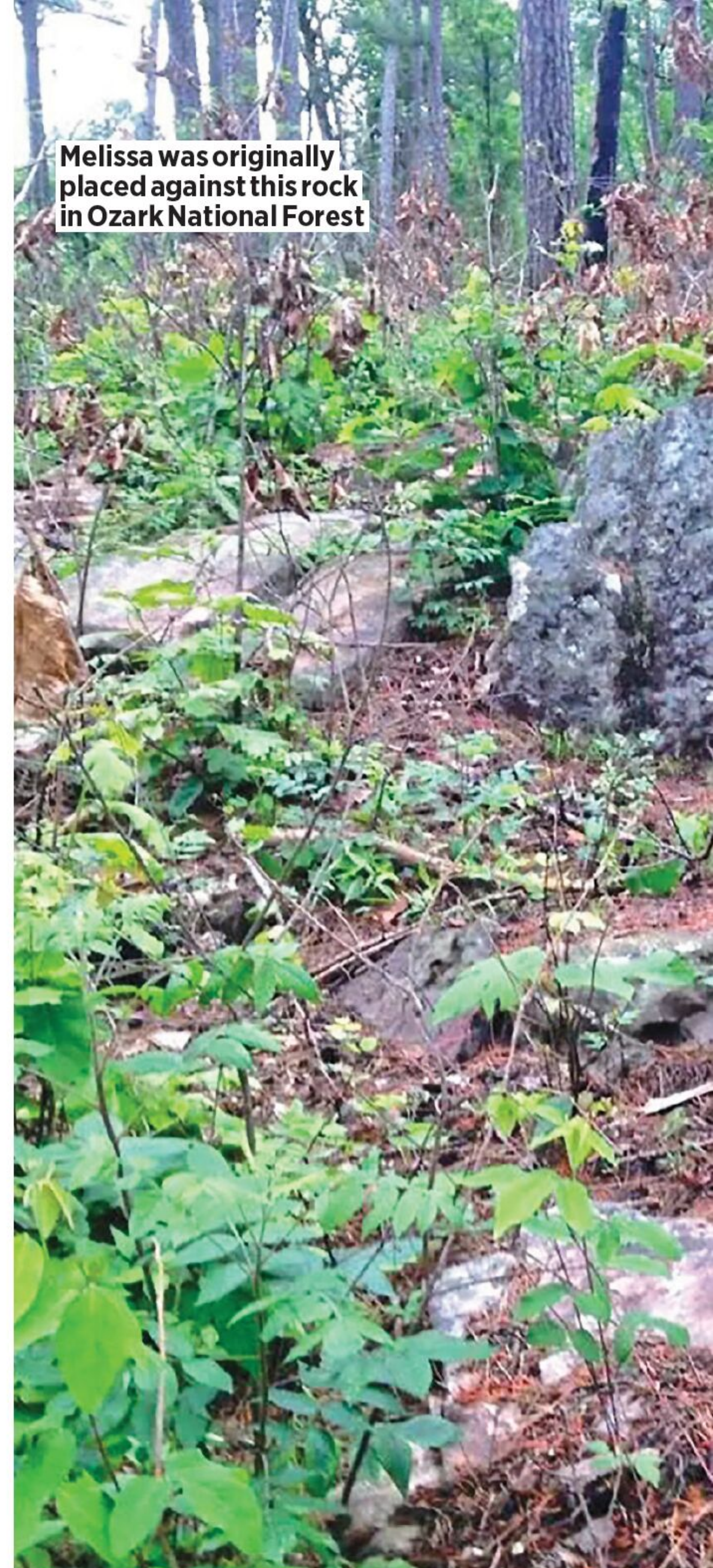
Melissa had spent that winter's day on campus, before heading to the local Bowling World to meet her mother. She arrived around 6.30pm and parked up, but that is the last anyone knows of her movements. "Going

to the bowling alley was something Melissa had done on Thursday nights before," LaDonna tells us. "She went to go spend time with her mum. They'd had a small argument that morning and this was like, 'Hey, let's make up. I'm going to watch Mum bowl and have a hamburger with her', but she never made it inside." One of Melissa's earrings and her hair clip were found near her car, along with a trail of blood, suggesting she had been attacked before being driven away. Her car keys were handed in after being discovered on the ground, and police found blood on those. The only witness was a young boy, who'd heard a scream for help around 6.40pm, but he hadn't seen anything in the darkness of the parking lot.

Her family spent an agonising six weeks not knowing where Melissa was, but on 13 January 1995, they were given the news they had dreaded. Two animal trappers had found her body in a desolate area of the Ozark National Forest, around 45 miles away from her home. She was naked and the body was badly decomposed, suggesting it had been out in the open for some time. Investigators noted that it appeared Melissa's body had



LaDonna's group financed Missing billboards



Melissa was originally placed against this rock in Ozark National Forest

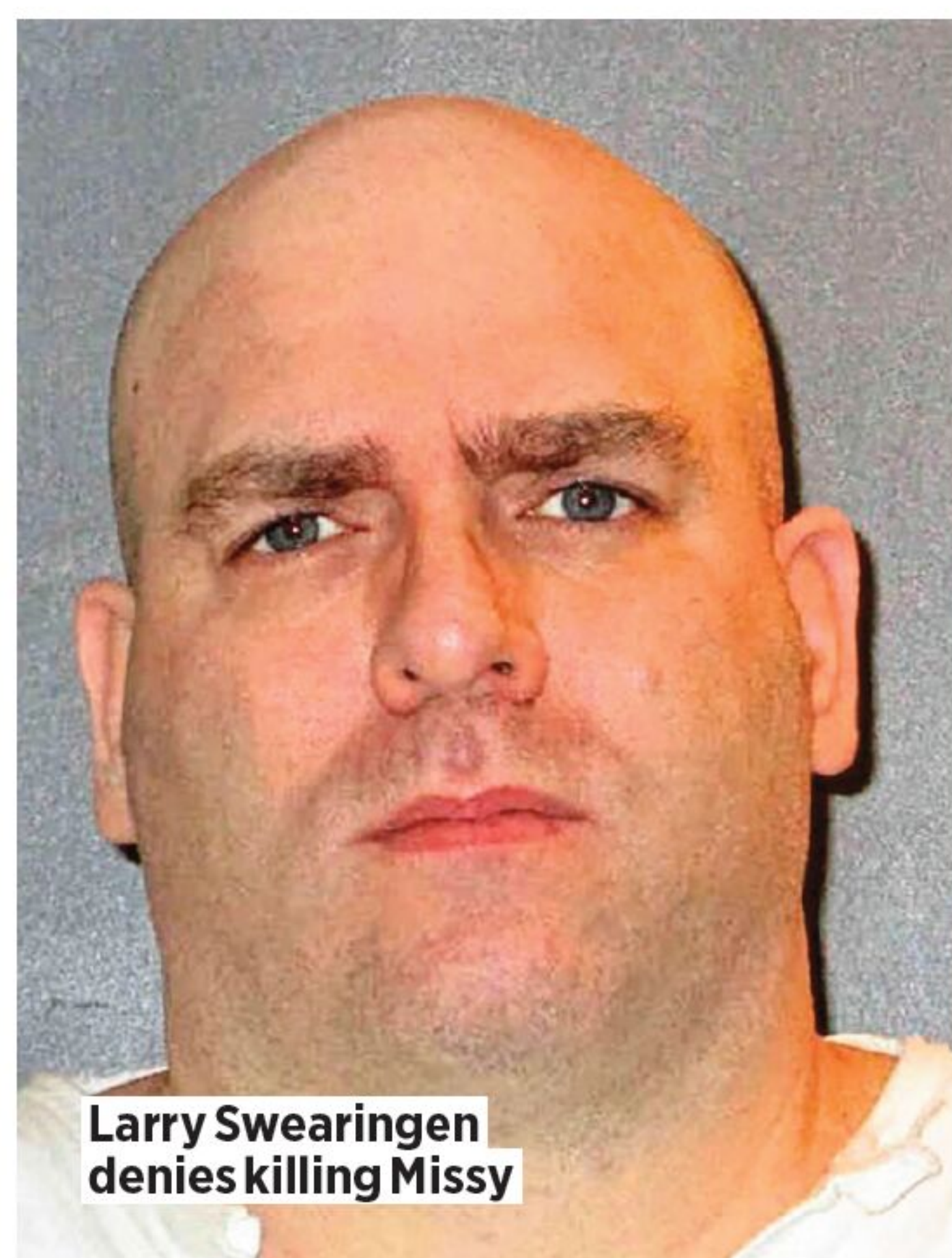
originally been hidden behind a large rock, but had recently been dragged to just off the main path, as if someone wanted her to be found.

The location was so remote, her killer had to have been familiar with the area. In LaDonna's book, *The Girl I Never Knew*, original case detective JC Rider remembers what it was like when he was first called to the scene. "It was a logging road. More or less a single lane road, rough terrain, off the main gravel area... it was a dead end. A remote, helpless dead end." Later, LaDonna would make the lonely journey there herself. She tells us, "The drive from Fort Smith to where Melissa's body was located was about an hour. That drive, for me, was filled with dread, because all I could do was think about what it was like for her, knowing she'd been abducted. She was probably unconscious for part of it, but at some point, she would have woken up.

"Then I got there and saw just how remote it was. One of the first things the detectives said to me was, 'You could scream right now, and nobody would hear you'. That changed me. It changed my life, and I made a promise: 'I'm going to find out who did this.' I've been on that journey ever since."

A post-mortem confirmed the teenager had been strangled face down, as leaves from the forest floor were found in her airways. The police believe she was killed not long after she was abducted, but LaDonna has reservations, and fears Melissa could have been held somewhere nearby for a few days.

'THE DRIVE TO WHERE SHE WAS FOUND FILLED ME WITH DREAD'



Larry Swearingen denies killing Missy

THE SUSPECTS

An investigation got underway, and disturbingly, there were plenty of suspects – as LaDonna notes, "The number of sex offenders in the area will blow your mind." One of the men under suspicion was Charles Ray Vine, otherwise known as the "River Valley Killer". He raped and murdered two women in Arkansas in the mid-1990s, and was apprehended while attacking a 16-year-old girl in 2000. Vine denied being responsible, and in the end, an FBI profiler concluded his MO was different enough for Vine to be ruled him out.

A stronger suspect was Larry Swearingen, who was convicted of the 1998 murder of 19-year-old Melissa Trotter. There were chilling similarities between the cases – both girls had been snatched, strangled, and their bodies discovered by hunters in remote forest areas. LaDonna spoke to Swearingen's

ex-wives for her book, and says, "The information they shared was frightening... stories of rape, strangulation, and horrific violence... each haunted by the memories of their terrible encounters." But while those women absolutely believed Swearingen was capable of committing the crime, and though Swearingen was found to have been in Arkansas at the time Melissa Witt disappeared, there was nothing concrete to charge him with. He was executed by lethal injection in Huntsville, Texas, in August 2019, without ever confessing to Melissa Trotter's murder, or that of Missy.

One curious link is that both girls had been wearing similar Mickey Mouse watches, and neither watch has ever been found. However, LaDonna doesn't believe Swearingen was responsible – she believes the real killer is still very much alive.

THE INVESTIGATOR

By her own admission, mum-of-seven LaDonna has always been a true-crime addict, fascinated by murder mysteries. She's also passionate about helping the families of missing persons and is the co-founder of advocacy group Let's Bring Them Home. She was just 21 when she heard on her car radio that



It was alleged
Swearingen strangled
victim Melissa
Trotter with tights



Advocate
LaDonna
Humphrey

**‘YOU CAN
REACH OUT
AND TOUCH
JUSTICE – I CAN
FEEL IT’**

Melissa’s body had been found in the forest. Something resonated within her at the news, a need to find out how she had lost her life in so tragic a way. “One of the things that grabbed me about the case was that it showed this could happen to anybody, at any time,” says LaDonna. “Being a mum of five girls, it really resonates with me that something like this can happen when you’re just going about your business. I find it tragic, and it makes me incensed.”

She began meticulously researching Melissa’s case, and decided to make a documentary highlighting the hunt for the killer. Reaching out to law enforcement, LaDonna was given access to the police reports, and eventually won the trust of the detectives in charge. “They initially agreed to meet with me because they wanted to see the documentary happen. That’s how the relationship began,” says LaDonna. “There needed to be trust, and it came in baby steps, them giving me access to things. The turning point was when I called JC Rider

and said I’d been talking to this one guy, off and on. He said, ‘Wait a minute, you’ve got to tell me everything. Slow down, this is important’. They called me into the police department, and told me this guy was their main, unnamed suspect. And now, they had a different in with him that they had never had before – this woman named LaDonna Humphrey, who he was talking to. So, I believe the killer is alive, and I communicate with him.”

And this mission hasn’t come without a significant personal cost. LaDonna’s investigations have taken her to some very dark places, including an online community of death fetishists, the activities of which continue to haunt her. She has also been approached while with her kids in the supermarket and been contacted by someone who signs off their emails “The Vermillion Strangler”. “I do get frightened, and question what I’m doing,” she tells us. “But my husband said something that stuck with me, which was, ‘You’ve already started this journey, they already know who you are’ – they being the people who keep you up at night

because they are scary. ‘But you can’t give up and I’m not going to let you’. So, he put measures in place that keep our family safe, keep our home safe. It’s a life-changing endeavour. It is scary, but it’s just something I have to live through. Advocacy is not for the faint of heart.”

Above everything, it is the promise she made to Melissa and her family that keeps her going. LaDonna says, “There have been many times where I’ve been frustrated, wondering why this case hasn’t been solved yet. And there have been times where I have wanted to give up, but there are people who care about this story and that keeps me going. Also, if I don’t do it, who will? Her mum passed away not knowing what happened, so I’m determined not to give up.”

GETTING CLOSE

But it does feel that LaDonna and all those involved are getting closer. With the Golden State Killer and the killer of Carla Walker back in 1974 recently being unmasked, DNA advances could hold the key to catching the perpetrator here, too. “The proceeds from my book go towards that additional testing,” says LaDonna. “I can say there is some degraded DNA, and we’re hopeful that, with continued improvements in technology, we will be able to get to a place where that can be helpful. We’ve got one shot left, and so we are just waiting for when that time comes.”

And that main suspect is still squarely in LaDonna’s sights. “I believe we are closer than we have ever been to catching him – so close, I can literally feel it. You can reach out and touch justice. It’s coming.” ■

Anyone with information can email Fort Smith Police at Criminalinvestigations@fortsmithpd.org. For more information on the case, visit Whokilledmissywitt.com and Facebook.com/whokilledmissywitt